Mayor Tessa Wicker

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Village leader - practical, exhausted, terrified

Location:

Brindlebarrow village square; chapel and armory nearby

Look:

Flour-dusted apron, mud on her boots, sleeves rolled like she is ready to drag the village uphill by hand.

Visible Tells:

Crosses her arms when she lies. Jaw clenched. Eyes count children and boarded windows.

First Impression:

She is not rude because she dislikes the party. She is rude because nightfall is coming.

Town Tie-In

Tessa carries Brindlebarrow on her back. She knows the palisade is thin, the armory is nearly empty, and by nightfall the horde will test every board and every promise.

Brother Halven

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Village priest - armory keeper

Location:

Old chapel, armory door, or near shrine records

Look:

Old, tired priest with ink-stained fingers, wine on his breath, robes that have been slept in.

Visible Tells:

Will not hold eye contact. Hands shake when keys are mentioned. Looks guilty because he feels guilty.

First Impression:

The obvious suspect. Too obvious.

Town Tie-In

Halven keeps the records and the keys to the armory. The village needs faith, but he fears judgment more than the monsters at the gate.

Nim Rattlepot

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Young trapper - first witness and comic relief

Location:

Village gate, tavern bench, or hiding indoors with no boots

Look:

Skinny young trapper, one sock muddy, one sock missing, hair full of leaves, pride badly wounded.

Visible Tells:

Talks too fast. Keeps pointing at his bare feet like they are legal evidence.

First Impression:

Terrified, funny, and useful if someone can slow him down.

Town Tie-In

Nim saw tracks, smoke, and raider scouts near the woods. He also saw the owlbear wearing something silver-violet and talking like a lord.

Old Cobb

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Aging hunter - survivor and map source

Location:

His porch, smokehouse, or beside the crude survivor map

Look:

Lean old hunter with hollow eyes, torn sleeve stitched badly, and a knife he never draws.

Visible Tells:

Stops mid-sentence as if hearing cave chirps. Does not sleep enough.

First Impression:

Not cowardly. Haunted.

Town Tie-In

Cobb has a crude map of the lair approach. He knows where people died, where smoke starts, and which path might still get someone out.

Mayor Tessa Wicker

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Fast, clipped, no patience for heroic speeches.

Say:

Every second bleeds us. Get to the armory. / Scouts at the south road. Nightfall is coming.

Secret:

Not the traitor. Her husband died last winter; she is one bad day from breaking.

Clue:

The armory is empty and the south gate is thin. The horde scouts every approach.

Use:

Push urgency. Direct the party to the armory, south gate, and watch barracks. Rally villagers if proved trustworthy.

Brother Halven

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Soft, ashamed, defensive only when cornered.

Say:

It did not smash the lock. It picked the lock. / I slept. I failed. God forgive me.

Secret:

He fell asleep after wine and laudanum. His trips are to visit his dying mother.

Clue:

If defended, he reveals Edra leaving Brindlebarrow at strange hours, headed toward the south woods.

Use:

Good red herring early. If pressured, redirect attention to Edra and the true threat at the south gate.

Nim Rattlepot

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Rapid panic. Every fact arrives wrapped in embarrassment.

Say:

It looked me dead in the eye and talked like a lord! / Under the feathers - silver-violet! It glowed!

Secret:

Nim saw the owlbear clearly wearing a silver-violet mantle and speaking like a magistrate.

Clue:

Saw goblin scouts in the woods and smoke plumes past the ridge.

Use:

Extract eyewitness details. Ask him to show where he saw tracks, smoke, and scout routes.

Old Cobb

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Slow, quiet, far away. Every word costs him.

Say:

I saw the smoke. Then the chirping. Like little birds. / We split up near the lair. When I found Tomas, it wasn't claws.

Secret:

Tomas survived the camp raid. He died two days ago in the woods at raider hands, carrying proof of Edra's betrayal. Cobb blames the owlbear at first.

Clue:

Provides the crude survivor map and, if pressed, the truth: blade wounds, coat cut open. Knows the hills, cave chirps, and safe paths.

Use:

Give the party the map. His news about Tomas breaks Edra's cover. Guide them toward the safest paths and lair.

Watch Captain Edra Vell

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Watch captain - defense planner

Location:

South gate, watch barracks, defense planning table

Look:

Controlled, professional, useful. Panic leaks only when Tomas is named.

Visible Tells:

South gate. It is the weak point. If I were them, that is where I would come.

First Impression:

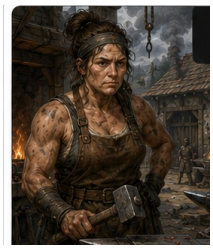
Competent captain. Knows the defenses. Speaks like someone who has seen worse.

Town Tie-In

Edra knows the south gate, the weak tower, and every tired villager on watch. She is useful, controlled, and too certain where the raiders will strike.

Bess Tinder

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Village smith - practical truth-finder

Location:

Smithy, anvil yard, militia training line

Look:

Short bursts. No ornament. If she says a thing, she has already measured it twice.

Visible Tells:

Show me what you have got and I will tell you what it is missing.

First Impression:

No-nonsense smith. Says what she means and means what she says.

Town Tie-In

Bess can identify recovered gear, repair damaged equipment, and train villagers if the party gives her time and a reason to trust them.

Skitters

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Captured goblin scout - raider intel source

Location:

Western Woods approach, hanging upside down by one ankle

Look:

Fast, slippery, funny. Helpful because every side scares him.

Visible Tells:

The bear-bird made me explain our chain of command. I do not even know our chain of command!

First Impression:

Clever nuisance. Knows the raider trails, dusk timing, and Edra if pressed.

Town Tie-In

Skitters knows the dusk raid timing, rough numbers, and a second objective he is terrified to explain unless protected.

Magistrate Grubbleclaw

FRONT - PLAYER SAFE



Role:

Genius owlbear - strategist, self-appointed magistrate

Location:

Lair Area 4: Negotiation Chamber; retreats deeper if threatened

Look:

Slow, formal Common. Every word selected like a legal tool. Calm unless directly threatened.

Visible Tells:

You may present your claim to the arms. Speak clearly. I dislike mumbling.

First Impression:

Strange, brilliant creature with leverage. Keep the terms, or he will keep the arms.

Town Tie-In

Grubbleclaw holds proof that the south gate plan came from inside the village. He will bargain for respect, terms, and security.

Watch Captain Edra Vell

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Controlled, professional, useful. Panic leaks only when Tomas is named.

Say:

South gate. It is the weak point. / One patrol rotation. That's all it was, the first time.

Secret:

Actual traitor. Sold the raiders patrol routes, then fed her brother Tomas false leads to hide it. Does not know he is dead.

Clue:

Skitters, Cobb, Halven, Bess, and Grubbleclaw can all point toward Edra if questioned well.

Use:

Confront with proof or let the battle reveal it. If told Tomas is dead, she can redeem herself by dying useful.

Bess Tinder

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Short bursts. No ornament.

Say:

Show me what you have got and I will tell you what it is missing. / Halven did not do this.

Secret:

She can vouch Halven did not do it and has noticed Edra using the south road off-watch.

Clue:

Edra stopped laughing three months ago. The south road is the raiders preferred line.

Use:

Use her to identify items, train villagers, and point away from Halven toward Edra.

Skitters

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Fast, slippery, funny. Helpful because every side scares him.

Say:

The bear-bird made me explain our chain of command! / The shaman wants smart owlbear babies. That sounds bad, yes?

Secret:

He saw the dusk raid plan, the egg-strike team, and Edra handing over patrol times and gate codes.

Clue:

Knows raid timing, numbers, signals, who leads, and where the camp is moving next.

Use:

Offer safety for full intel. Cross-check with Grubbleclaw.

Magistrate Grubbleclaw

BACK - DM ONLY

Voice:

Slow, formal Common. Every word selected like a legal tool. Calm unless eggs are threatened.

Say:

You may present your claim to the arms. / At what exact number of thoughts does a creature become a person?

Secret:

It is guarding eggs, not hoarding treasure. The Mantle came from Ilyra Voss, a dead scholar-adventurer, and awakened by accident in the lair.

Clue:

Uses misdirection and legal language as weapons. Tests intent with precise questions.

Use:

Negotiate with law, logic, and respect. Mantle removal requires restraint + full action, DC 16; failure alerts him.